

We've noted the concept that everything needs מזל, including a ספר תורה בהיכל, quite a number of times before. I particularly bring that idea up with the order and the position of all the פסוקים in the פרשיות. In פרשיות, the last פסוק is תעשון, אשר תעשון, כי תבוא.

I wanted to bring a particular מעשה which I found in the sefer שאלתי brought down by R' Zilberstein in the name of a sefer called אגן הסהר which I can honestly say I have never heard of, but this is such a געוואלדיגע example of this pasuk that I felt it was worthy of inclusion. It is brought down in the name of R' Avraham Genachowski זצ"ל, and it says here that he was very fond of the following story which he would often retell, drawing important lessons from it.

Years ago, there was a pious and God-fearing חכם תלמיד who lived in Kiryat Arba, a small city near Haifa. He toiled in Torah day and night. He and his family lived in dire poverty. One day his wife told him that things could not go on that way any longer. There was no food in the house. He would have to find a way to earn a living.

The man went to a textile factory in Kiryat Arba and spoke to the manager. "I would like to work just a few hours every day. Will you hire me?"

The manager agreed. He gave him a relatively easy job with low pay. The man thanked Hashem and was happy with the arrangement. He would have plenty of time to learn after work and even during work.

One day, when he came to the factory, he noticed that all the supervisors and workmen seemed very tense. There were hushed conversations all around. "What is going on?" he asked one of the workers. "Why is everyone so nervous and busy talking instead of working?"

They told him that the factory had ordered a huge new machine from overseas, the most sophisticated of its kind. The machine was going to arrive that day and was supposed to be installed in a large pit that had already been dug in one of the factory's main rooms. After installation, the bottom part of the machine would be underground, and the top part would protrude above ground. In order to get the machine into the room, the workers had made a large opening on the side of the building through which a crane would come in with the machine and then lower it into place.

However, there was a problem. They had just discovered that the crane truck, which was already on its way to the factory, could bring the machine into the room and set it on the floor, but it could not lower it into the pit. If the crane let go of the machine just above the pit so that it would drop into the pit, it would break. The cranes in those days were not as sophisticated as the cranes today. It seemed like the only solution to the problem would be to break open the entire roof of the factory, bring in a special crane that could lower the machine down from above and set it into the pit. Obviously, this would be terribly costly and would disrupt the entire factory's production.

As soon as our חכם תלמיד heard the problem, he had a brilliant idea. "Please take me to the factory manager," he requested. No one took him quite seriously. They wondered what this frum guy could possibly have to tell the manager. But when he repeated his request, they pointed him in the right direction. The manager was in the main room inside the pit. He rushed over to him and found him in a state of utter despair. "Listen, I have a simple solution to your problem," he told the manager. The manager looked at him in disbelief. The problem had stumped all of the top experts. What simple solution could this worker offer him?

"Okay, let's hear it," he said in a condescending tone. "What do you have to say?"



“I suggest we fill the pit with huge chunks of ice,” the תלמיד חכם suggested. “Not ordinary ice, very strong ice you make by adding salt to the water before it’s frozen. When the pit is full of ice and level with the floor, the machine can be placed on the ice. As the ice melts, the machine will slowly sink down into the pit gently without breaking.”

The manager was stunned by the brilliant simplicity of the plan. They did as the man suggested and it worked perfectly. The manager wanted to give his ingenious employee a generous bonus for his idea, but the תלמיד חכם chose to make a קידוש השם and refused to take a cent.

When R’ Avraham Genachowski heard this story, he was awed by the man’s wisdom and resourcefulness. He also pointed out there are a few lessons to be gleaned from this incident:

Number one: This story shows you how great the Torah is and how it makes people wise. Our pasuk.

Number two: Every problem, no matter how tough, has a solution. All you need is to strain your brain and daven to Hashem - not in that order - to grant you the wisdom and insights to find the way out of your predicament. (I must tell you as an aside, frequently, I have been faced with problems and I finally say, “You know, I give up. Hashem, I’m leaving it up to you. I tried my השתדלות. Hashem, please help me.” Invariably, that תפילה works. Try it, it does.)

Number three: R’ Genachowski also taught that this story can be viewed as a משל. Every person has ice in his heart. This ice causes his heart to be unsettled. He lacks true joy, inner peace, and satisfaction. However, a person can slowly melt this ice by thinking about his own insignificance. When a person internalizes the fact that he is but a tiny speck in Hashem’s enormous universe, and if he acts with true humility, the ice surrounding his heart will gradually melt and his heart will settle itself securely into its proper place.

As a P.S., many of you have heard of the name Rabbi Menachem Genack. He’s the head of the OU and a chavrusa of mine from our school days. He is an אייניקל of R’ Genachowski, and he always enjoys hearing stories about his Zeidy’s גדלות.

